



ROAD TO COMMAND

The route to captain

Guide for future captains · Helvetic Airways E2 / E1

Your flight plan from first officer to the left seat. Each waypoint shows what Helvetic requires, where the requirement comes from and which topics you need to master.

ROUTE OVERVIEW

SFO Senior first officer	MINIM Meet the experience minima	APPLY Application	SELEC Selection	CMDCO Command course	LIFUS LIFUS as upgrader	RLSE Release and consolidation	CPT As captain in line operations
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As of: 5 October 2026

OM-A 2 App. 1 · 4.1 · 5.2

Senior first officer

Typical stage before the upgrade, not formally a prerequisite for it.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ 1500 h total time, of which at least 500 h multi-pilot on CS-25 aeroplanes
- ☐ ATPL skill test passed
- ☐ Senior copilot training per OM-D 5 App. 4.1 completed
- ☐ Recognisable by 3 stripes on the uniform

Source: OM-A 5.2.7

Study in JetQ

Article: Upgrade to Commander: Requirements and Process

Quiz: Upgrade & Command Course

Quiz: Qualification & Recent Experience

Meet the experience minima

Only those who meet these minima may apply. Hours count only from the end of your LIFUS as copilot.

Criterion	Joined ab initio or < 1000 h MP(A)	Joined with > 1000 h MP(A)
Licence	Valid EASA ATPL or all conditions for its issue met	Valid EASA ATPL or all conditions for its issue met
Rating	IR MP(A)	IR MP(A)
Flying activity	3 years within Helvetic, covering at least 2 winter seasons (December to February) with active flying duty	4 years with an EASA Air Ops operator (or 2 years plus 2 years in similar commercial operations) and 1 year within Helvetic from the initial line check
Hours	2500 h on CS-25 in MP(A). Reduction via an individual MoC possible, but never below 2200 h. 2200 h for active CRI/IRI within Helvetic or its partner ATO	2500 h on CS-25 in MP(A)

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Age at least 25 and below 65
- ☐ Valid passport
- ☐ Valid medical class 1; copy of the renewal to TNG at least 10 days before expiry
- ☐ English language proficiency at least level 4
- ☐ Completed apprenticeship (EFZ or equivalent) or higher education (e.g. Matura)
- ☐ ATPL or all conditions for the ATPL met, IR MP(A)
- ☐ Hours and years according to your track (table)
- ☐ At least 2 winters with active flying duty (ab initio track)

Source: OM-A 2 App. 1.2.3, 5.2.1

Study in JetQ

Article: Upgrade to Commander: Requirements and Process

Article: Ground De-/Anti-Icing

Article: Contaminated Runways, RWYCC and Braking Action

Quiz: Upgrade & Command Course

Quiz: Qualification & Recent Experience

Quiz: Health Precautions, Alcohol & Medical

Application

Helvetic prefers to fill commander vacancies with internal upgrade candidates.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Wait for Helvetic's announcement (sent to all flight crews when needed)
- ☐ Written application with motivation letter to the Nominated Person Flight Operations (FOP)
- ☐ Review your own training records beforehand: LPC/OPC, EBT, line checks

Source: OM-A 2 App. 1.1.1, 1.4

Study in JetQ

Article: Upgrade to Commander: Requirements and Process

Quiz: Upgrade & Command Course

Selection

Four steps. Competencies are assessed, not just hours.

1. Review of training records

All trainings and checks are reviewed, as are the prerequisites per 2 App. 1.2.3.

2. Flying skills evaluation

Bridge course: you present a topic to peers on an empty whiteboard, 5 to max. 7 minutes, no PowerPoint. Then a simulator assessment in a medium jet (e.g. EMB190, A220/320) with simplified speeds: CLB 210 kt, CRZ 250 kt, holding and initial APR 210 kt, intermediate APR 180 kt, final APR and GA 140 kt. You are PF and may give the PM tasks, but you stay responsible. Assessed are SAW, WLM, PSD, LTW and COM as well as KNO and FPM. For internal upgraders: rarely practised, complex manoeuvres such as dual thrust loss in cruise close to an adequate airport, flying on STBY instruments and a visual approach from any position and energy state, plus decision-making scenarios in the LOFT part.

3. Psychological assessment

Per DIN 33430, by at least two assessors. Focus: leadership, decision making, social competence and emotional intelligence, dyadic cooperation, safety awareness. Result as a traffic light: green no concerns, amber certain concerns with mitigation, red major concerns.

4. Decision board

Operational board with ACM, FOP, TNG and CMR, plus an interview with corporate management. Three possible decisions: positive; negative at present time (new process earliest after 12 months and once only); negative (no new process within Helvetic).

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Able to present a bridge course topic on the whiteboard without notes
- ☐ Fly raw data, holdings, intercepts and wind corrections confidently
- ☐ STBY instruments and visual approach from any energy state practised
- ☐ Able to apply decision-making models (FORD, PPAA, WTFN, ACPC, NITS)

Source: OM-A 2 App. 1.4, 1.6.2, 1.6.3, 1.6.4

Study in JetQ

Article: Commander: Responsibility and Authority

Article: Upgrade to Commander: Requirements and Process

Quiz: Decision Making & CRM

Quiz: Upgrade & Command Course

Quiz: Diversion & Emergency Leadership

Command course

Mandatory for every commander per OM-A 5.2.1. Process and content are defined in OM-D 2.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Ground training: commander's responsibilities and command CRM (EASA ORO.FC.105)
- ☐ Simulator training incl. LOFT in the left seat
- ☐ Operator proficiency check as commander
- ☐ Line training in command under supervision (LIFUS)
- ☐ Line check as commander
- ☐ Route and aerodrome competence for your destinations

These items follow the EASA framework for command courses (ORO.FC.205). The exact Helvetic implementation is in OM-D 2.

Source: OM-A 5.2.1, EASA ORO.FC.205

Study in JetQ

Article: Commander: Responsibility and Authority

Article: MEL in Practice: Categories, (O)/(M) and Dispatch

Article: Planning Minima: Destination, Takeoff and En-route Alternates

Quiz: Commander Authority & Responsibility

Quiz: Commander Dispatch Decisions

Quiz: Passengers & Cabin

Quiz: Reporting & Documentation

LIFUS as upgrader

You fly in the left seat, accompanied by a line training commander (LTC).

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Below 6 days and 16 route sectors: LTC in the right seat
- ☐ After that the LTC may move to the jump seat, at the LTC's decision
- ☐ Completed with the line check or LOE after the command course

Source: OM-A 4.1.10, 4.1.3.1.1

Study in JetQ

Article: Commander: Responsibility and Authority

Quiz: Commander Authority & Responsibility

Quiz: Decision Making & CRM

Release and consolidation

After release you count as an inexperienced crew member until consolidation is reached.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ No pairing with another inexperienced pilot until 100 h and 10 sectors within 120 days, or 150 h and 20 sectors
- ☐ Hours and sectors count from the LOE after the command course
- ☐ CAT II/III: upgraders already on type get no RVR increment. Only new commanders without an EASA CAT II/III qualification fly with RVR + 100 m until 100 h or 40 sectors on type

Source: OM-A 4.1.3.1, 5.2.9

CPT

WAYPOINT 8/8 · ON BLOCKS

As captain in line operations

What you must keep valid from now on.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Recency: 3 takeoffs and 3 landings as PF in the preceding 90 days (aircraft or simulator level CG, C or D); up to 120 days with a TRI
- ☐ Absence of more than 4 months: requalification training (RQT)
- ☐ Route and aerodrome competence: within 12 months (CMD only); your OFP signature covers the crew's self-familiarisation
- ☐ LOE and EBT within 12 months
- ☐ Medical: 1 year below 60, ½ year from 60
- ☐ LVO: 3 CAT II/III approaches between two EBT modules
- ☐ Safety equipment, security and RVSM training within 12 months

Source: OM-A 5.2.2, 5.2.9, 5.2.13, 5.2.15.1



Authority and responsibility

- What the commander may and must decide, also towards ops and handling
- Responsibility for crew, passengers, cargo and aircraft from boarding

Study in JetQ

Article: Commander: Responsibility and Authority

Quiz: Commander Authority & Responsibility

Quiz: Commander, Crew Responsibility & Chain of Command



Decision making and CRM

- Apply the FORD, PPAA, WTFN, ACPC and NITS models confidently
- Distribute workload, use the PM deliberately, communicate the decision

Study in JetQ

Article: Commander: Responsibility and Authority

Quiz: Decision Making & CRM



Dispatch decisions

- MEL/CDL, (O) and (M) procedures, dispatch with restrictions
- Planning minima, type A/B approaches, TAF VIS versus RVR (rounded to 100 m)

Study in JetQ

Article: MEL in Practice: Categories, (O)/(M) and Dispatch

Article: Planning Minima: Destination, Takeoff and En-route Alternates

Article: Type A and Type B Instrument Approach Operations

Quiz: Commander Dispatch Decisions

Quiz: Dispatch: MEL, CDL & Tech Log



Fuel as commander

- Justify extra fuel and coordinate with the company
- Declare MINIMUM FUEL and MAYDAY FUEL in time

Study in JetQ

Article: Fuel Policy: every fuel component in detail

Article: In-flight fuel management, MINIMUM FUEL and MAYDAY FUEL

Quiz: Fuel Policy

Quiz: Fuel Policy & In-flight Fuel Management



Passengers and cabin

- Disruptive passengers, refusal of carriage, cabin briefing
- Medical events on board and cooperation with the SCA

Study in JetQ

Quiz: Passengers & Cabin

Quiz: Passengers & Special Categories

Quiz: Cabin Safety & Flight Deck Access



Diversion and emergency leadership

- Make and implement a diversion decision in a structured way
- NITS briefing to the cabin, communication with ATC and company

Study in JetQ

Article: In-flight fuel management, MINIMUM FUEL and MAYDAY FUEL

Quiz: Diversion & Emergency Leadership

Quiz: Abnormal, Emergency & Incapacitation



FTL and commander's discretion

- FDP extension by discretion: limits and reporting duty
- Recognise fatigue and take it seriously, also in the crew

Study in JetQ

Article: Flight Time Limitations: FDP, Rest and Discretion

Quiz: Commander's Discretion & Fatigue

Quiz: FTL Daily Check



Reporting and documentation

- ASR, occurrence reports and tech log correctly and on time
- Journey log, OFP signature and retention

Study in JetQ

Quiz: Reporting & Documentation

Quiz: Security, Occurrence Reporting & Leasing



Flying skills

- Raw data, non-radar approaches with GRID, MORA, MSA, intercepts and wind corrections
- 2D approaches with CDFA, visual approaches with high DA/MDA

Study in JetQ

Article: Type A and Type B Instrument Approach Operations

Quiz: Approach, Go-Around & Landing

Quiz: Minimum Altitudes & Altitude Awareness



Winter and low visibility

- De-/anti-icing, holdover times, contaminated runways and RWYCC
- CAT II/III, LVTO and cold temperature correction

Study in JetQ

Article: Ground De-/Anti-Icing

Article: Contaminated Runways, RWYCC and Braking Action

Article: Low Visibility Operations: CAT II, CAT III and LVTO

Article: Altimetry, Transition and Cold Temperature Correction

Quiz: Winter: De-/Anti-Icing & Cold Weather

Quiz: Winter: LVP, Fog & Contaminated Runways

PERSONAL PROFILE (OM-A 5.2.1)

- Clearly takes responsibility for own actions
- Communicates in a clear, binding and socially acceptable way
- Self-discipline and self-criticism above average
- Basic flying skills (raw data, navigation, situational awareness) at an advanced level
- Proficient in the relevant parts of PANS-OPS and in the Helvetic operations manuals

PREPARATION PLAN

From 12 months before

Check your logbook: hours after LIFUS, years, winter seasons. Check licence, medical and LP level for validity.

6 months before

Read OM-A chapters 1, 4, 5 and 8 in a targeted way. Get the Road to Command quizzes in JetQ above 75 %.

3 months before

Practise bridge course topics on a whiteboard, 5 to 7 minutes without notes. Practise raw data and STBY instruments in the sim and, where permitted, on the line.

1 month before

Run decision-making models through real cases. Put your motivation and your strengths and weaknesses into clear words for the decision board.

The preparation plan is a JetQ recommendation, not an OM requirement.

Based on OM-A 2 App. 1, 4.1 and 5.2. The content of the command course itself is in OM-D 2, which JetQ does not have; there the EASA framework (ORO.FC.205) is described. The valid manuals and the announcement by Flight Operations are always authoritative.